Guns for Geeks

By Chris Crutcher

SAMMY: My mother is a child therapist and my dad works for the Department of Children's Services, and we've been a receiving home for kids being put into foster care as long as I can remember. Gene [Taylor] was at our house probably ten times, sometimes so hungry he couldn't keep from stuffing himself like a famine victim at the dinner table, and sometimes sporting some really creative bruises and burns. And that's just what I know. Imagine what the whole truth might be.

INTRODUCTION

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SAMMY: Mr. Beemer's U.S. Government class. Beemer is [the] boys' basketball coach, but academics is even more important to him than athletics. On this day, amidst our Second Amendment discussion, Beemer was promoting the idea of context.

BEEMER: How many of you - and I'd like a show of hands here rather than pistols - believe the framers of our Constitution considered when they included that particular right that we might someday have guns that fired more than one bullet with one squeeze of the trigger? *(pause as he is obviously met by silence from the class)* Or that our society might turn out to be one of the world's most violent in the new millennium.

ROY: Guns don't kill people . . .

BEEMER: I know: People kill people. But they do it with guns.

ROY: Not always. An old guy in Spokane was beaten to death with a golf club

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last week. *(laughing)* How come people don't ask for a ban on golf clubs?

BEEMER: *(smiling)* Don't get me wrong, guys. I'm not trying to rewrite the Constitution, or remove your right to bear arms. I'm just asking - if the context had been different, would the framers have written it differently?

SAMMY: Linda Cross raised her hand, and I flinched. Linda's little brother had killed her littler brother last year playing with their father's handgun, there for purposes of protection and supposedly out of reach.

LINDA: Maybe people kill people, but if Christopher hadn't gotten his hands on that gun, Marvin wouldn't be dead. *(glaring at Roy)* Even if he could have gotten his hands on a golf club.

SAMMY: I looked out the window then to avoid the discomfort I felt about Linda's remark . . . [It was then that] the door opened, and we looked up to see Gene Taylor in a long rider's coat, leather cowboy hat and boots, his face contorted into a grim intention that certainly changed our lives forever. The front of the coat swings back and, scanning the room with narrow eyes, he brings up a lever-action .30-.30.

He shoots Roy Salley first, in the head. Roy is there, a recognition on his face, staring down the barrel, then gone. It unfolds in slow motion. Roy pitches backward, his head striking the blackboard like a melon.

Megan Gratten is next, probably only because she sits next to Roy there in the back of the room. Her eyes widen in astonishment as the bullet rips through her neck, then she lies tipped over, an awful sucking sound coming from the wound. Low moans escape terrified throats. I am so aware of weight, of gravity's imposing force, welding me to my spot. Something inside me says do something. It is Gene Taylor, whom I have watched come and go from our foster house like a church mouse; a wall-

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hugger who makes a career of being invisible, now reducing the toughest of us to our knees. His eyes are dark and consumed as he swings the rifle barrel in search of his next victim.

Gene tells us to put our heads on our desks. When no one responds he screams it, firing two more rounds. One strikes Mr. Beemer in the shoulder and the other slams into Carly Pruitt's stomach. Carly is my girlfriend and best friend. I leap from my chair then, kneel and cradle her head in my lap, only to look up at the long tunnel that is his rifle. Carly breathes shallow gulps of air, her eyes shut tight against the pain. *(to Gene)* "Don't, man. Please."

Our eyes meet and his finger twitches on the trigger, and maybe he remembers I was decent to him in our home, because he motions with the barrel for everyone to put their heads down. They do so in unison. Mr. Beemer is conscious, slumped forward at his desk gripping his shoulder, groaning, blood trickling down his forearm onto the back of his hand. I hope his mind is working; Gene isn't finished. He glares at me then, his lip curls, and I listen for the bang.

GENE: *(Screaming)* Keep your heads down!

SAMMY: [His] eyes locked on mine for that dreadful moment, and [then he] swings the barrel away, leaving his back to me. I beg myself to rise; can't.

GENE: *(forcefully)* Things are going to change around here . . . The first will be last and the last will be first. *(chuckling)* The first will be dead and the last will be first.

SAMMY: He points the rifle at Johnny Waller now, a quick, first-string point guard - with a quicker mouth - and a straight-A student. He walks toward him, his back still to me. [He] glances over his shoulder to smile at me, and shoots him through the back of the head point-blank. Johnny slumps like

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a sack of potatoes.

GENE: *(to Johnny's corpse)* Get it together.

SAMMY: "Get it together." *Get it together* is Johnny's rallying cry bringing the ball up court - it's also what he said to Gene Taylor in front of our sophomore speech class when Gene froze in the face of a one-minute improvisational speech two years ago.

GENE: Big mouths first, crybabies and whiners next.

SAMMY: At the desk Beemer pulls himself up, stands wobbly legged, holding his shoulder, taking slow, deep breaths. He moves around the desk.

GENE: Let's see, who's next? *(looking over the class of students)* Who else called me pussy?

BEEMER: *(Standing up straight)* Gene. You have to stop.

GENE: *(Turning to Beemer)* Stop? *(a shrill laugh)* I'm just getting started. All these scores to settle, so little time. *(he looks Beemer up and down)* You're not looking so good, sir. Why don't you have a seat? *(Turning back to the students)* "Now, where were we?" *(he walks to another student and raises the pistol to his head)*

BEEMER: Pussy. If you're looking for people who called you pussy, I'm your guy.

GENE: *(not turning around)* Never heard you say that, sir. I shot you because you didn't stop them.

BEEMER: In the teacher's lounge. I called you that in the teacher's lounge all the time. 'Wouldn't have Taylor on any of my teams. Way too big a pussy.' *(his knees buckle, but he catches himself)*

GENE: *(turns, eyes blazing, jaw set. He walks toward Beemer with his gun now pointed at the teacher)* "Get on your knees, sir." *(Beemer slowly kneels, his eyes locked with Gene's)* Open your mouth. *(laughing)* I want to see you explode.

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BEEMER: *(A long hesitation)* No.

GENE: Put the barrel of the gun in your mouth and I'll let one person go.

BEEMER: *(glances around at the class, he starts to open his mouth, then)* No, it has to be more than one . . . All of them, Gene, or you don't get to watch my head explode.

GENE: *(screaming)* Open your goddamn mouth!

SAMMY: And his voice jars me loose. I leap up as he turns; I never had a chance. But from his knees, Beemer blocks him like an offensive guard, knocking him off balance as T.J. springs headlong from his desk, snatching the gun as Gene pulls the trigger, burying the bullet in the ceiling. Beemer pins Gene to the floor as a student pulls the classroom door open and teachers swarm in. In the distance, sirens wail.

**********SCENE BREAK**********

SAMMY: I got away from school out the back way before the local news media could catch me, and hightailed it to the hospital to see how Mr. Beemer was. He told me T.J. and I had saved a lot of lives, that he'd never have had a shot at Gene if I hadn't diverted his attention, and who knows who else might have been hit if T.J. hadn't gone for the gun. *(to Beemer)* Yeah, but what about Johnny? . . . Coach, Gene had his back to me. I couldn't have stopped him from shooting Roy or Megan or even Carly. But his back was to me before he killed Johnny." *(gasping for air)* I froze.

BEEMER: Don't do that. *(motioning Sammy closer)* Sam, listen to me. All of us in that room know something about ourselves that we didn't know before today. Nothing's ever going to be the same for anyone who was there. But there's only one person to blame for this, and that's Gene. He came into the room with his guns and opened fire. Everything that happened after that was in response to it. Okay?

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SAMMY: I took a deep breath, saw Gene's back again, saw Johnny slump forward. I wanted to believe what Coach said, and maybe as time goes on it'll be easier. But I can't shake the sensation of being paralyzed, of knowing some of my best friends, my girlfriend, for God's sake, stood to die, and I couldn't move.

**********SCENE BREAK**********

SAMMY: *(to audience)* The following days went by in a blur for me. Funerals. I couldn't tell you which came first or what was said - only that whatever was said, it wasn't enough. It wasn't right. Johnny Waller and Megan Gratten and Roy Salley would never sing another song or dribble another ball or see another sunset.

I jump up one morning, to drive through the deserted streets toward Waller's Chevron. I pull up next to the one self-serve pump. Mr. Waller, [Johnny's dad], is inside counting bills into the cash register. I'm desperate to know if anyone has talked with him about that day - if anyone has told him Gene Taylor's back was to me for what seemed like an eternity before he shot Johnny, and that I didn't move.

I top off my tank and walk inside to pay.

WALLER: How ya been?

SAMMY: *(to Waller)* Okay, I guess. You know. *(to audience)* God, does he have any idea?

WALLER: *(nodding)* Wanted to thank you again for Johnny's funeral, for carryin' the casket. That's a hard thing to do . . . Carry a dead classmate.

SAMMY: There have been a lot of hard things around here lately.

WALLER: I want you to answer me a question . . . Truthfully. . . . You think my boy was a smartass?

SAMMY: *(heart leaping into his throat)* Yeah, well, maybe. No more than me. No more

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than a lot of guys.

WALLER: You think his big mouth got him shot?

SAMMY: *(to audience)* I flash to that day in sophomore speech class when he told Gene Taylor to "get it together," watched Gene turn red and drop his gaze to the floor, then sit down without a word. *(to Waller)* Yeah, maybe. Johnny wasn't exactly, like, sensitive, but hey, who is?

WALLER: *(slowly wiping his hands on a grease rag from his back pocket)* I'm afraid I might a taught him to be that way. *(staring at a spot a few inches from his nose, almost talking to himself)* I'm kinda the quiet type, always felt a bit afraid to push things. Wanted him to stand up, not be like me. I'd just feel more peaceful if I thought my boy wasn't gone 'cause of somethin' I done.

SAMMY: *(to audience)* I remember Beemer's words. *(to Waller)* Hey, there are lots of guys around with bigger mouths than Johnny. I mean, who knows why Gene picked who he picked. Johnny's gone because Gene Taylor was f*** up. Pardon my language.

WALLER: *(thinking for a moment)* It's a minefield . . This life.

SAMMY: *(to audience)* Mr. Waller was a foot soldier in the Korean War. He knows what a minefield is. Suddenly I just want to help him; to say some truth that takes the edge off. I decide on the big one. *(to Waller, hesitantly)* Before he shot Johnny, Gene was . . . Well, he turned his back to me. I mean, I don't know if anyone told you . . . *(choking up)* I don't know whether . . . maybe if I'd moved faster - I was scared *(moving toward the door)* I was so damn scared. I'm sorry, Mr. Waller. *(exits)*

(to audience) In my peripheral vision I see him moving toward the door as I climb into my car, think he's going to yell something at me, but I keep my eyes focused straight ahead and pull out, catching a glimpse of him in

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my rear-view mirror standing out on the concrete, his hand half raised.

**********SCENE BREAK**********

SAMMY: At a broad clearing near the top of the mountain, I pull off. I roll down my window, let the cold air rush in as I take a deep breath, trying to fill my body with something clean. The thoughts pass in single file, in twos, in stampedes. I don't light on one, images actually, more than words: Gene standing in the doorway to the classroom. Gene leaning over a plate of food in our house, embarrassingly ravenous. Roy Salley's smug look as he taps Gene on one shoulder and slaps the opposite side of his head as Gene turns to look. Johnny Waller with his head on his desk. The back of Gene's head as he walks away. Beemer in his hospital bed. Carly bleeding on the floor. Mr. Waller's sad face.

The talk now is all about forgiveness. How can you forgive someone who has done something you can't even wrap your mind around. [And] along with the talk of forgiveness, sometimes in the same sentence, is talk of who is to blame. It's as if we can't get past any of this unless we find out who to hang it on. . . Well, I've had some time to think, and I have a theory.

No one is to blame. Everyone is to blame. I mean, Gene is to blame because he did it; no one can argue with that. But when I remember his face - his eyes - it's hard to think he had any control over what he was doing. We could blame his parents - a mother for being there too much and a dad for not being there at all - but it's not as if they sat around and said "Let's f*** up our kid so bad that he goes out and opens fire." It's not hard to imagine that *their* folks did a worse than mediocre job of parenting too. Mr. Waller made the statement I like best.

WALLER: I don't care who's to blame. My son is dead and that's never going to be

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any different.

SAMMY: Don't get me wrong. I hate Gene Taylor for what he did. And I hate him because of how cowardly I felt, and still feel, for what I did and didn't do when I had to face him. But I also can't help seeing him at my house, gorging himself, satiating one hunger while not touching the other; hiding his scars, grateful for the respite and at the same time resentful toward me, because he has never had the things I take for granted - food, love, Nikes, a girlfriend. Gene Taylor had to feel embarrassed coming to our house. How messed up is that? A guy gets treated like shit, then has to be ashamed when folks discover that he's a guy people treat like shit.

[Now] I go out to Waller's Chevron every Thursday morning at the crack of dawn. When I got there this morning, he was sitting with his feet up on the front desk, reading the paper.

WALLER: *(reading from the paper)* Says here if they try [Gene] as a juvenile, he's out on his twenty-first birthday at the latest. If they try him as an adult he could get life with no possibility of parole. *(puts paper down and smiles tiredly)* They're trying to figure out how to punish him *(slowly shaking his head)* Hell, don't they know guys like Gene Taylor are punished *before* they do their deed? . . . . Now, what are we going to do about that?

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